CSE0001 - Digital Literacy

Project Report

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Introduction

This project report is submitted as part of the CSE0001 Digital Literacy course at VIT Bhopal University. The project is built around a real-world scenario where I take on the role of a Student Digital Ambassador - a peer representative responsible for helping fellow students navigate the digital landscape safely, professionally, and responsibly.

Over the course of five tasks, this portfolio demonstrates my understanding and practical application of key digital literacy skills. These tasks span five modules of the course: creating awareness content, building a professional digital presence, exploring coding and collaboration platforms, practising professional email communication, and understanding cybercrime threats and prevention strategies.

All tasks have been completed using free, browser-based tools. The outputs have been organised into a single GitHub repository (digital-literacy-project), which serves as both the submission medium and a living component of my professional digital portfolio. This report documents each task in detail, including the tools used, the work completed, and personal reflections on key learnings.

Task 1: Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

What I Made

For Task 1, I created a one-page Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic using Canva (canva.com). Canva is a free, browser-based graphic design tool that requires no prior design experience, making it ideal for this assignment. I selected a clean, modern presentation template and customised it with relevant content, colour schemes that reflect a tech-focused theme (blues and whites), and icons sourced from Canva's built-in library.

What My Design Shows

The infographic covers four key topics relevant to first-year students:

- What Digital Literacy Is: A brief, student-friendly definition explaining that digital literacy is the ability to use technology effectively, critically, and responsibly.
- Useful Digital Tools for Students: A visual grid highlighting platforms such as Google Workspace, Notion, Canva, and GitHub, with icons and one-line descriptions.
- Safe Internet Practices: A short checklist covering strong passwords, avoiding public Wi-Fi for sensitive tasks, recognising phishing emails, and enabling two-factor authentication.
- Professional Online Presence: Tips on maintaining a LinkedIn profile, keeping social media content appropriate, and the importance of a consistent, professional username.

Reflection

The tool I used was Canva (canva.com). The design process was relatively straightforward, but the most challenging aspect was fitting all four topic areas onto a single page without making the design feel cluttered. I found it particularly interesting to experiment with Canva's alignment and spacing tools to achieve a clean, grid-like layout. One key learning was understanding how visual hierarchy - using different font sizes and bold headings - guides a reader's eye through the content in a logical order. I also discovered that less text is often more effective in an infographic; replacing long sentences with short bullet points and icons significantly improved readability.

The exported infographic has been saved to the task-1-presentation/ folder of my GitHub repository.

Task 2: Student Digital Portfolio

Platforms Set Up

For Task 2, I created and configured accounts on three platforms: GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle. Each platform serves a distinct purpose in the academic and professional ecosystem, and together they form the foundation of my digital identity as a computer science student.

Platform Descriptions

GitHub (github.com): GitHub is the world's largest platform for software development. It is used by students, developers, researchers, and companies to host code repositories, track changes, and work on projects as a team. I created a profile README - a special repository named after my username - which currently includes my name, branch, year, and a brief statement about my learning goals. This README acts as a public-facing introduction for anyone who visits my GitHub profile.

LinkedIn (linkedin.com): LinkedIn is a professional networking platform used by over 900 million professionals globally. It is the primary platform where recruiters search for candidates and where students can connect with industry professionals, alumni, and potential internship coordinators. I completed the Education section of my profile, adding my current B.Tech degree, institution name (VIT Bhopal University), and expected graduation year (2029).

Kaggle (kaggle.com): Kaggle is a data science and machine learning community platform owned by Google. It offers datasets, competitions, free online courses (notebooks), and community discussion forums. As a CSE student, Kaggle will be particularly valuable for learning data science, practising with real-world datasets, and eventually participating in competitions to build my project portfolio.

How I Plan to Use These Platforms Over Four Years

Over my 4-year B.Tech programme, I plan to use GitHub to host every significant academic project, making my code publicly available and demonstrating my progression as a developer. I will keep my LinkedIn profile updated after each semester with new skills, certifications, and projects, and use it actively during my internship search in Years 2 and 3. On Kaggle, I intend to complete their free data science learning paths and attempt beginner competitions by Year 2.

Screenshots of all three profiles have been added to the task-2-portfolio/ folder in my repository.

Task 3: Coding & Collaboration Platforms

Part A - Coding Practice Platform

For Part A, I created an account on HackerRank (hackerrank.com) and completed the 'Solve Me First' challenge - an introductory problem that asks the user to write a function adding two integers. Although this was a beginner challenge, it introduced me to HackerRank's code editor interface, the concept of test cases, and how submissions are evaluated automatically.

I also attempted the Python Introduction challenge (Print Function), which required printing integers in sequence without spaces. HackerRank provides instant feedback - if a submission fails a test case, it shows which input produced the wrong output, helping me debug efficiently. After completing both challenges, I earned a star on my profile. A screenshot of the completed challenges and my badge has been added to task-3-platforms/.

Part B - Google Workspace Collaboration

For Part B, I created a Google Form titled 'Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz' using Google Forms (forms.google.com). The form contains exactly 5 questions designed to test a student's basic understanding of digital literacy concepts:

- Question 1 (Multiple Choice): What does 'digital literacy' primarily refer to?
- Question 2 (Short Answer): Name one tool you use for online collaboration or studying.
- Question 3 (Multiple Choice): Which of the following is NOT a safe internet practice?
- Question 4 (Multiple Choice): What does '2FA' stand for?
- Question 5 (Short Answer): What should you do if you receive a suspicious email from an unknown sender?

The form includes both multiple choice and short answer question types as required. Responses are automatically collected into a linked Google Sheet, which I have configured to record response timestamps. A screenshot of the form and the linked Google Sheet (response view) has been added to task-3-platforms/. The form link has also been included in the README of my GitHub repository.

Reflection

Using HackerRank helped me realise that coding is a skill that improves incrementally - even simple problems teach you about syntax, logic flow, and how automated testing works. Google Forms, meanwhile, showed me how powerful cloud collaboration tools can be. Creating the quiz took less than 15 minutes, yet the result is a fully functional, shareable resource that automatically organises responses - demonstrating how Google Workspace tools significantly reduce administrative overhead for academic tasks. Both platforms will be directly useful throughout my degree.

Task 4: Professional Email & Etiquette Guide

Task 4 required me to demonstrate understanding of professional email communication by drafting sample emails and compiling an etiquette checklist.

Part A - Professional Email Drafts

Email 1 - Requesting Assignment Extension from a Professor

A formal request to a teacher asking for an extension on a project deadline, using appropriate tone, subject line, and sign-off.

Email 2 - Expressing Interest in a Summer Internship

A professional email from a student to an internship coordinator at a company, expressing interest in a summer internship opportunity

Part B - Social Media Do's and Don'ts Checklist

I compiled a checklist of 12 rules covering:

- Subject line clarity - always specific, never left blank
- Greeting format - formal (Dear Mr/Ms) vs semi-formal (Hi [Name])
- Tone - professional, neutral, and free from slang or emojis
- Structure - opening, body, and closing in logical order
- Attachments - named clearly, referenced in the body
- Reply time - within 24 - 48 hours for professional emails

Reflection - Communication Scenario

A well-known example of poor digital communication is the 2013 case of Justine Sacco, a communications director who posted an ill-judged tweet before boarding a long-haul flight to South Africa. By the time her plane landed, the tweet had gone globally viral, sparking widespread outrage and resulting in the loss of her job before she even reached her destination. The situation illustrates how a single, thoughtless social media post - made in seconds - can have irreversible personal and professional consequences. What could have been done differently is straightforward: a simple pause to reconsider the potential audience and impact of the post before hitting 'send' would have been sufficient. This scenario reinforced for me the importance of treating every public post as a permanent, global statement, regardless of how casual or private the intent may feel in the moment.

Task 5: Cybercrime Awareness

Part A - Case Study: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

Cybercrime Type: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

While researching cybercrime, I was surprised to learn how easily people can fall victim to online payment fraud through simple tricks like fake calls and messages. Many users are unaware that sharing an OTP or approving a payment request can lead to immediate financial loss. I realized that even educated individuals can become victims if they are not cautious. This topic made me more aware of the importance of digital safety and responsible online behavior. One habit I will personally change is to always verify any payment request or message before taking action. I will also avoid clicking on unknown links and ensure that I never share sensitive information like OTPs or PINs with anyone. This awareness will help me stay safe and prevent cyber fraud in the future.

Analysis

This case study highlights how UPI fraud mainly exploits human behaviour rather than technical weaknesses. Attackers rely on urgency, fear, or attractive offers to manipulate users into making quick decisions without proper verification. The step-by-step process shows that the fraud succeeds only when the victim shares sensitive information (OTP/PIN) or approves a payment request unknowingly. This indicates that lack of awareness and digital literacy is a major contributing factor. Another important observation is that students and elderly individuals are more vulnerable due to limited experience or over-trust in digital communication. The consequences are not only financial but also psychological, leading to stress and reduced confidence in online systems. Overall, this case study emphasizes that user awareness is the strongest defense against such cybercrimes. Simple precautions like verifying sources, avoiding unknown links, and understanding how UPI works can significantly reduce the risk of fraud.

Part B - Stay Safe Online: Prevention Checklist

General Cybersecurity Tips for College Students:

- Always check the sender's email address carefully before clicking any link - look for subtle misspellings such as 'vitbhopa1.ac.in' instead of 'vitbhopal.ac.in'.
- Enable Two-Factor Authentication (2FA) on all important accounts (email, GitHub, LinkedIn) so that even if your password is stolen, your account remains protected.
- Never reuse the same password across multiple platforms. Use a password manager such as Bitwarden (free) to generate and store strong, unique passwords.
- If you receive an urgent email asking you to click a link, navigate to the official website directly by typing the URL in your browser - never click embedded links in unsolicited emails.

- Keep your phone's operating system and apps updated regularly; many updates patch security vulnerabilities that attackers exploit.
- Use a VPN when connected to public Wi-Fi (at cafes, libraries, or college common areas) to prevent your data from being intercepted.

UPI & Financial Safety Tips (Mandatory):

- Never share your UPI PIN, OTP, or bank account details with anyone - including people claiming to be from your bank or a government agency. Legitimate organisations never ask for these over a call or message.
- Beware of 'collect requests' on UPI apps (PhonePe, GPay, Paytm): a collect request means someone is asking to TAKE money from you, not send it to you. Students are frequently tricked into approving collect requests believing they are receiving money.

Reporting Channels:

- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal: cybercrime.gov.in - report phishing, financial fraud, cyberbullying, and identity theft online.
- National Cyber Crime Helpline: 1930 (available 24x7) - call immediately if you have been a victim of online financial fraud to initiate a freeze on the fraudulent transaction.

Reflection

The most surprising discovery during my research for this task was how sophisticated modern phishing attacks have become. I had always assumed phishing emails were easy to spot - poorly written and obviously suspicious. However, researching CERT-In reports and documented cases showed that attackers now use AI tools to craft grammatically perfect, contextually accurate emails that are nearly indistinguishable from legitimate

institutional communications. The detail that attackers even replicate logos, font styles, and sender name formats was genuinely alarming.

One habit I will personally change as a direct result of this task is always hovering over or carefully reading hyperlinks before clicking them. I will also enable 2FA on every platform I use and set a monthly reminder to review app permissions on my smartphone. These are small steps, but they significantly reduce the risk of becoming a victim.

Conclusion

Completing this Digital Literacy Portfolio has been a genuinely practical and eye-opening experience. Across five tasks, I moved from understanding digital literacy as an abstract concept to applying it through real tools, real platforms, and real scenarios. Building my GitHub and LinkedIn profiles, creating a Google Form quiz, drafting professional emails, and researching phishing attacks each reinforced a different dimension of what it means to be a digitally literate student in 2026.

Perhaps the most important takeaway is that digital literacy is not a static skill - it requires continuous learning and adaptation as technology and online threats evolve. The platforms I have set up and the habits I am building now will compound in value over my four years at VIT Bhopal and beyond. As a Student Digital Ambassador, I now feel equipped not only to protect myself online but also to guide my peers in doing the same.

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